

Individual Assignment
Getting Personal with Data: Production and Visualisation/Visceralization of a Dataset

BACKGROUND

This assignment is a slightly modified version of a project assignment developed by [Franziska Zirker who teaches at the University of Marburg](#), Germany. She designed this activity to encourage students to engage with different datasets—both current and historical—and to explore creative ways of presenting ideas in social science beyond just writing. As artist [Tali Weinberg points out](#), *“Data is powerful because it packs a huge amount of work, knowledge, and time into something we can understand quickly. But that’s also its downside—it hides the real-world stories and efforts behind it.”*

We’ve lived in a data-driven world for a long time, but with smartphones, the internet, cloud computing, and now AI, we’ve become constant producers and consumers of data. This assignment helps you think critically about how data shapes our daily lives—often without us even noticing—and how it influences who we are.

What is Visceralization?

Visceralization is a cognitive technique that strengthens memory and emotional connection to information by linking it to vivid sensory or bodily experiences. It turns abstract ideas into tangible, emotionally charged mental images, making them more memorable and impactful.

Data Visceralization in Art and Research

Data visceralization is a method [artists and researchers](#) use to move beyond abstract representations of data, instead highlighting its real-world origins and consequences. It also challenges the rigid divide between quantitative (numbers) and qualitative (stories) data.

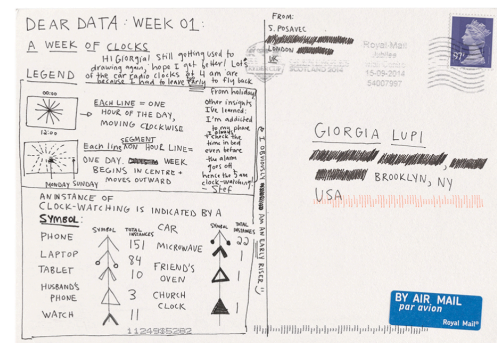
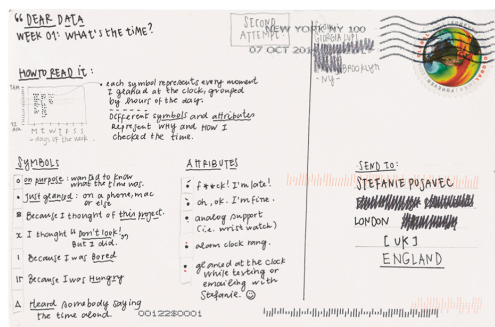
For example:

- **Tali Weinberg’s *Climate Datascares*** uses [weaving, sculpture](#), and thread drawings to physically represent climate data.



Image Source: <https://www.taliweinberg.com/datascapes>

- **Giorgia Lupi and Stefanie Posavec's *Dear Data* (2016)** features hand-drawn [postcards tracking](#) weekly emotions like complaints, indecisions, laughter, and goodbyes.



Drawing her first postcard, Giorgia had an idea for her whole collection: from now on every time she tracks something related to Stefanie, or to Dear Data, she uses a special pen to represent it!

• pink ink pen!

This week Giorgia and Stefanie tried gathering data in small notebooks (ridiculous), but soon switched to making notes on their phones (much easier). Stefanie's favourite clock to capture a bell tolling the time in a town in Devon.

Image Source: <https://www.dear-data.com/theproject>

Historical Roots: W.E.B. Du Bois' Data Portraits

These approaches have early precedents in the work of **W.E.B. Du Bois** (1868–1963), a pioneering African-American sociologist and civil rights activist. His *Data Portraits* (or "Data Plates"), created for the [1900 Paris Exposition](#), [used innovative charts](#), graphs, and infographics to visualize socioeconomic conditions of African Americans—decades before modern data science existed.



Image Source:

<https://yangdanny97.github.io/blog/2024/04/26/dubois-challenge>

ASSIGNMENT: PERSONAL DATA VISCERALIZATION

Objective: Create a dataset about an aspect of your life, represent it creatively (visually or sensorially), and reflect on the process.

Step 1: Choose & Collect Your Data

- Select a personal topic (e.g., daily habits, emotions, social interactions, media consumption).
- Decide how to collect data (tools/methods):
 - Digital: Apps, spreadsheets, WhatsApp chats, social media.
 - Analog: Pen/paper, photographs, audio recordings, self-made sensors.
- Save the dataset as a **.csv file** (use Excel, Google Sheets, or a text editor).

Step 2: Document Your Process (1-2 pages)

Include:

1. **Title & your name**
2. **Data description:**
 - o What did you collect and why?
 - o How did you gather it? (tools, time/location, method)
 - o Ideally the data must be collected daily if not every few hours or so, to allow meaningful representation over two weeks.
3. **Data structure:**
 - o Explain column headers, variables, and codes (e.g., "Column A: Timestamp, Column B: Mood Rating (1–5)").
4. **Reflection:**
 - o Why this topic? What challenges did you face?
 - o How does your data reveal something about your life?
 - o Design choices and challenges.
 - o How the process changed your view of data.

Step 3: Creative Representation

- **Visualize or "visceralize"** your data in an engaging way:
 - o Conventional: Charts, graphs, infographics.
 - o Sensory/Tactile: Weaving, sculpture, soundscapes, yarn, wood, watercolors, or acrylics, interactive objects.
- Consider: Who is your audience? What emotion or message should they take away?

Step 4: Submit

- Your **.csv dataset**
- **Documentation** (Step 2)
- **Creative representation** (photo/video if physical)
- **Short reflection** (300–500 words) on:
 - o Design choices and challenges.
 - o How the process changed your view of data.

EXPECTATIONS:

The broad idea is that you will explore the situatedness of data and the production of knowledge beyond traditional written formats. Your dataset must be related to your everyday life viz. political posters you see, verbal contributions in classes, food you eat. For example, one student examined their WhatsApp chat for word frequency, painting the resulting visualization on a vase. This project highlights the emotional and personal aspects of data and raises important questions about surveillance and data economies. You have between 2–4 weeks to independently produce and visualize/visceralize data. You must collect data for at least 10 days (e.g., 7th–16th April). Longer periods (e.g., 7th April–1st May) are allowed. You must submit your files via Moodle from **20th April till 4th May midnight (final deadline)**.